



S. Asia

Palitana Temples

Hundreds of Jain temples and shrines spread across a mountain site in western India

The Shatrunjaya hills outside the town of Palitana in Gujarat are sacred to the Jain religion, which has millions of followers across India. Especially associated with Rishabhanatha, the first Jain *tirthankar* (“spiritual leader”), the site has become a “city of temples,” offering a crowded vista of domes, towers, and spires. There are about 860 temples on the hills, arranged in nine clusters. The first temples were built in the 11th century, but the majority date from the 17th century.

Temples of the sacred hills

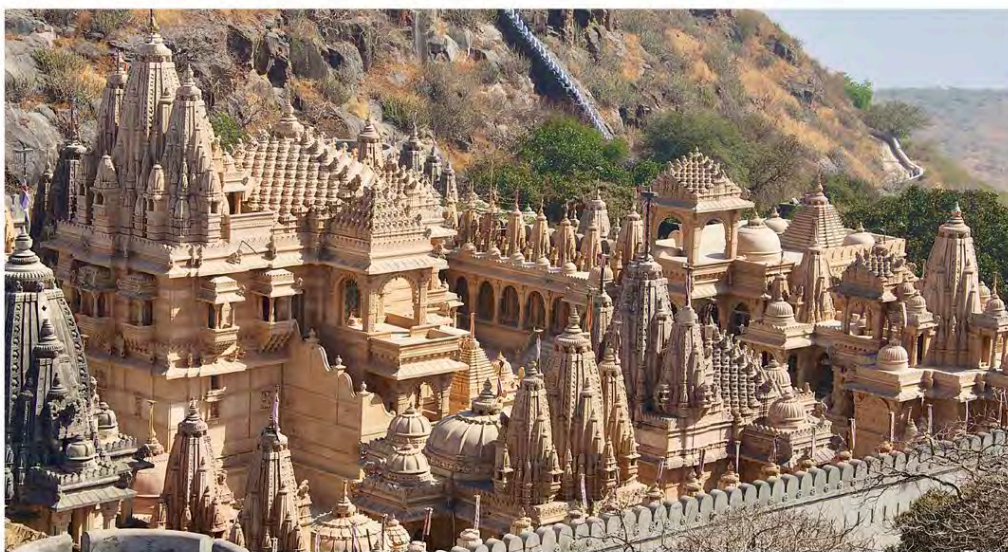
The temples and shrines are made of marble, with exquisitely carved pillars. Their classic form is a square, with four doors opening toward the four points of the compass. The buildings house statues of gods, often decorated with gold and precious stones. The Adishwara temple, the largest in the complex, is dedicated to Rishabhanatha. Considered one of the finest religious buildings in India, it is decorated internally with images of dragons and lions.

Today, worshippers performing devotional acts mingle with tourists visiting the temples. All must leave by nightfall, because no one—not even Jain priests or monks—is allowed to spend the night on the hills. Visitors need to have a reasonable level of fitness, as reaching the Adishwara temple involves a climb up steep pathways with more than 3,500 steps.



△ SCULPTURAL RELIEF

Stone carvings are one of the major decorative features of the Palitana temples. They illustrate a variety of scenes from Jain mythology.



△ CROWDED HILLSIDE

Packed close together on the slope of a hill outside Palitana, the hundreds of ornate Jain temples and shrines were designed to make a dazzling impression on worshippers. The religious monuments stand within a walled enclosure.



△ PILGRIMS AT MECCA

An aerial view shows the Great Mosque flooded with Muslim pilgrims during the annual *hajj*. The central courtyard surrounds the Kaaba, the holiest shrine in the Islamic world.

THE KAABA

The Kaaba is a cube standing at the hub of the mosque's courtyard. The Black Stone embedded in the building's eastern corner, of unknown origin, is especially revered. The gold-embroidered silk *Kiswa* draping the exterior walls is changed annually. Pilgrims have to walk around the Kaaba seven times during *hajj*.

